

## 27<sup>th</sup> February 2026 - Joey Glider officially donated to the Australian Gliding Museum.

I'd like to provide some background on my father, **Keith Jarvis**, and clarify a few points about the Joey and other aircraft projects. I hope this helps future generations better understand his contributions to gliding and sport aviation in Australia.

### Keith Jarvis – The Man Behind the Aircraft

- **Keith Jarvis (14 November 1923 – 11 May 2015)** was a WWII pilot, flying Avro Anson aircraft and later serving as co-pilot on Consolidated B-24 Liberator bombers, based out of Fenton Airfield and various locations in Indonesia.
- After the war, he became an Air Traffic Controller, eventually retiring in 1982 in Adelaide.
- From the 1950s through to the 2000s, he was one of Australia's best-known and most respected homebuilders of aircraft winning multiple awards.
- Keith chaired the inaugural meeting of Ultralight Aircraft Association of SA in 1955 which we hold the minutes of. Others have purported the Association began with 'a few blokes chatting about aircraft outside the Qantas hangar at Essendon at lunchtime' in 1955.

Dad's passion for flying began in the 1930s while growing up in Cook on the Nullarbor Plain. A weekly mail biplane would arrive, sparking his imagination. He built what he called "crude" model aircraft from the weathered laminations of old tea chests.

His father, Eric Roy Jarvis, also had a notable history as a decorated WWI soldier perhaps encouraging Keith to join the RAAF.

I remember dad saying they offered him navigator but he was adamant he wanted to be a pilot. He said he did very well during training and often said 'he was a good pilot' which was a bit out of character for him as he generally understated his achievements. In fact, I'd class him as a 'perfectionist' given he always seemed to want to improve his aircraft builds amongst other things.

### The "Joey" Gliders

- The first aircraft Dad built was the **Joey Glider**, weighing just 135 lbs empty. There's a photo of him lifting it above his head at an airshow — which we'll happily provide to the museum.
- The Joey first flew on 11 January 1955 at Gawler, South Australia. I'm not sure what ultimately happened to that original aircraft.
- In about 1967, he built a second glider, the **J2**, featuring a cantilever wing. Unfortunately, he got sick of waiting for DCA to approve it and despite two successful test flights, he scrapped the J2 fuselage and reused the wings to create the **J3** (with struts) around 1970. We'll confirm the exact date once our research is complete.

*"The J2 was a one-piece cantilever wing adaption of the Joey Glider weight 140 lbs. Despite obtaining a comprehensive stress analysis, approval by the DCA was obstructive. After more than 6 months the glider was scrapped. The wings were modified and used in the J3 Joey glider. Two short flights were made at Gawler. "(KJ)*

- The conservative approach of DCA deeply frustrated him, as he was eager to advance gliding designs and recreational aviation in Australia.

Straight after building the Joey 3, he began what was to be Australia's first homebuilt aircraft project to commence construction (VH-UEI, Druine Turbulent), but due to again concerns over lack of DCA approval, he discontinued it and passed it to Duncan McCallum to eventually complete and gain approval. A couple of years later Keith built Turbulent VH -ULI. The media didn't help back then either. I recall an article that described ULI as a small homemade plane made from scrap timber and silk stockings or words to the effect.

### **The Powered Joey 2**

The Joey 2 was later fitted with a 160cc Victa lawnmower engine and flew for many years in the 95:10 ultralight category during the 1980s and 1990s.

I vividly remember my first flight in it. True to form, once strapped in, Dad handed me an old oil tin petrol tank and told me to wedge it between my legs or find a spot for it. "You'll be right," he said — then pull-started the engine and off I went.

What I forgot to ask was how long the fuel would last, so I kept it short.

It was incredibly noisy — exactly like a lawnmower — but it flew beautifully. The ailerons were so effective that after landing at Aldinga, I could keep the wings level with a trickle of throttle, turn 90 degrees off the runway, and taxi on one wheel to a stop near the hangars. Very civilised... in a slightly agricultural sort of way.

### **Some "Memorable" Flying**

Dad had a talent for memorable decisions.

- In the late 1950s or early 1960s, he flew original (unpowered) Joey from Gawler on a whim across the city of Adelaide. He climbed to 10,000 feet and felt confident with cumulus ahead, but lost height nearing the coast and found himself at 1,000 feet eyeing Morphettville Racecourse... during a race. Fortunately, he caught another thermal and continued. The DCA Regional Director later passed him in a corridor and dryly asked, "Still flying gliders, Keith?" That was apparently the extent of the reprimand.
- He was hand-launched off hills several times — and we have video footage of this, which we can provide. He made the paper in 1955 with the bright idea of beating the world gliding endurance record by slope soaring for 8 hours. Unfortunally, he must have forgot to check the weather forecast as a cold front came in. He found himself in cloud unable to lose height so he went on the lee side of the range in the rapid downdraft then popped back over the top again and sideslipped down the hill. He said it was so windy he had to sit there holding the controls until someone came to help him out. Crazy stuff.
- In 1978, after arranging to depart Adelaide Airport to perform a display over top of the Glenelg Birdman Rally, he became (to my knowledge) the only person to buzz the Adelaide Airport control tower. He came back very fast with a strong tailwind and wrapped a very steep turn so close to the tower I'd estimate about 10 metres from the cab. It was awesome to watch — he must have pulled a few G's in that turn. Fortunately, the film crew missed it. I imagine there may have been some spilled coffee, however, with dad overseeing Adelaide ATC at the time probably helped calm the staff on duty. Funny, he always denied it— until the truth emerged at his funeral, to considerable laughter.

### The Olympia, Australite and “Sunbird”

I’d also like to clarify a few matters involving the late Kevin Sedgman.

- In the late 1950s/early 1960s, Dad and Kevin built a glider called the Olympia. Most of the work — including wing construction — was done by Dad at our home at Plympton Park. Kevin later convinced dad to sell him the project, but according to dad, only paid for the materials. Dad was kind-hearted and easily persuaded but equally annoyed by this.
- In the mid 80’s, Dad built an aircraft called the **Australite**, which he designed from scratch and spent two years constructing. He later sold it to Kevin Sedgman for the value of the engine on the understanding it never be on sold. Kevin fitted a canopy and renamed it the “Sunbird,” claiming he built it.

This caused Dad considerable frustration. My brother Lynn and I respectfully ask the museum to recognise Keith Jarvis as the original designer and builder of the Australite/Sunbird.

(For what it’s worth, I think it looked better without the canopy - see photo)

### In Closing

I hope future generations will appreciate the Joey and my father’s broader contribution to gliding and sport aviation in Australia.

I still own his favourite aircraft — a modified Druine Turbulent (19-1201). There’s an entire additional story about the four Turbulents he built — and the many other aircraft projects totalling 13 all up— but that may be for another day.

Kind regards,

**Ian Jarvis**